

THE IMPASSE Rahul Gandhi and Bharat Jodo Nyay Yatra colleagues at the sit-down protest in Nagaon, Assam, Jan. 22

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which has been timed to favour the party in the 2024 Lok Sabha election. In 1992, weeks after the Babri Masjid had fallen, the then prime minister, the late P.V. Narasimha Rao, had reportedly observed: "We can fight the BJP, but how do we fight Prabhu Ram?" A similar dilemma now haunts the Opposition parties. They don't want to be co-travellers in BJP's Hindutva trajectory but are also aghast at the saffron party consolidating its grip over the massive Hindu vote bank in the name of Ram and religion. The challenge now is to balance the two diametrically opposite objectives and come up with a credible narrative to woo voters and stop the BJP's electoral juggernaut, now driven by the power of Ram.

NEW RULES OF THE GAME

Earlier, the first response against the BJP's majoritarian nationalism was to coalesce around the constitutional obligation to uphold the doctrine of secularism. That is no longer the refrain even among those political parties that have come together as the INDIA (Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance) bloc. If some are seeking to blend religion with other identities to build separate support groups, others are not even making a pretence of separating religion from statecraft. For instance, West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee boycotted the consecration in Ayodhya but visited Kalighat temple in Kolkata the same day before leading a harmony march with the heads of various religions. She sought to counter Modi's Project Ram by positing Bangla cultural identity against it. So, one week before the Ram temple inauguration, she invoked Bangla pride by asking the prime minister to recognise Bengali as a "classical language". Similarly, on the day former Maharashtra CM and Shiv Sena (UT) leader Uddhav Thackeray offered prayers at the Kalaram temple, where B.R. Ambedkar had led a satyagraha in 1930 as Dalits were not allowed to enter the premises then. Such a symbolic gesture has significance in a state with a 12 per cent Sscheduled Caste population.

In Delhi, Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) supremo and Delhi chief minister Arvind Kejriwal has tried to challenge the